

Is Gaming Good or Bad

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With the invention of the telephone, the way people interacted and behaved with each other changed forever. The radio has also been one such invention that has changed our lives as humans. It became an addictive evening time activity, similar to the family spending their nights in front of the television in the '90s.

Entertainment grew to progressively invade more and more sensations, but gaming was when entertainment truly arrived. Audio-visual interaction is too good to resist. Games are the most immersive entertainment available to people today. Even a casual gamer can end up spending a significant amount of time playing the same game rather than watching the same TV channel or listening to the same radio station, or reading a book.

Every time there is some technological progress, there is a flurry of discussion and debates over the social effects of these technologies. As technologies mature, a deeper understanding of their potential harm emerges. There's no doubt many spend a lot of time gaming, and this has raised one question from doctors, psychologists, concerned parents and educationalists – are games good or bad for you? We spoke to psychologists, surveyed children who are into gaming, interacted with the parents of these children, and looked at some international studies, to demystify what is generally a misunderstood activity.

Wake up, Mr Freeman...

Interestingly, several gamers are in a dilemma of sorts themselves. Most gamers are well aware of the problems that gaming can pose. In fact, serious gamers take adequate steps to shield themselves from harm. Even within a game, the older and more experienced players groom the newer players into playing responsibly.

Most parents are not aware of the game contents, or even understand what their children are up to. There are several questions that concern parents. How many hours a day of gaming is normal? Where should they draw the limit? Is it OK to play late night? How adversely does gaming affect children? To what will the child be exposed?

These are all valid questions, but the concerns are based on myths. Since games are a fairly recent phenomenon here in India it is natural that such questions should arise. Some clearing of the air is required. On one side of the coin, games, like any other repeated activity, make you really good at some things. Think of it as mental exercise. Games do not ruin eyesight, neither does watching television for a long time, or reading a book in the dark.

In fact, gaming is said to improve visual perception. For example, those who play first person shooters resolve closely packed objects better and learn to process information very quickly. Games train players to understand threatening situations and respond to them by dealing with panic. If a child is nervous or restless, then it is recommended to let the child play games to build focus. In fact, gaming is used as a therapy in some western countries for children with attention deficit disorders. Gaming also improves reflex and boosts hand-to-eye coordination.

Another myth is that exposure to games make children more violent. Children don't play games to be violent, they play it for



Using a gun meant to kill for climbing walls as a demonstration of skill

accomplishment – completing a task or a mission. They play a game to beat the game, not the fictitious beings in the game. A good example of this is the defrag mod for the popular combat shooter game *Quake3*. When several parents were complaining how violent the game was, where the objective was to shoot players with an arsenal of weapons, a group of people began to use the same weapons for performing stunts within the game. Videos were shared over the internet, and the community became a movement, a violent game was turned into an activity of skill and precision.

Games are typically very short, and single player games hardly ever last for more than eight hours at the highest level of difficulty. It's also very easy to get bored with games, so the resourceful gaming community comes up with innovative ways to play the game. An illustration of this is the speed-running community where gamers play to cross the game as quickly as possible, often using alternate routes and exploiting bugs in the game. There are plenty of secondary skills that are enhanced by gaming, including logical reasoning and memory retention.

Somebody set up us the bomb

On the other side, there's a lot that can go wrong. There have been instances of children going into coma, or even dying after prolonged gaming sessions. These intense sessions could last more than two days at a stretch, and are referred to as bingeing. There are cases where parents with young children were so addicted to games that their children were made to starve. An intense obsession for a game, or gaming in general, can develop to a point where playing a game is not a matter of choice, but a matter of compulsion. These, however, are isolated cases, and the majority of the gamers around the world are well-balanced people whose lives are not adversely affected by gaming.

Most of these problems cannot be blamed on the game itself. It's a result of faulty lifestyle choices, and an indicator of unhealthy behaviour. These include parents not spending enough time with their children, children not being encouraged to play outdoors and developing a psychological distance from reality. If the game were not the focus of the problem, something else almost certainly would be.

According to Shekhar Kunte, psychology trainer, "indulging in games makes the child mentally cut off from the real world.